SINGING ROYALS

Arijit Singh emerges the undisputed badshah of male playback singing; Shreya Ghoshal retains melody queen status among women artists

By SUHANI SINGH



AFP

Not since the glory days of Lata Mangeshkar has a voice become as dominant in playback singing as Arijit Singh's today. A ballad isn't deemed romantic if it doesn't have the Singh cadence. To little surprise, then, the reclusive singer, who has consistently topped the charts of music streaming apps as India's most popular artist, was also the number 1 singer for the respondents in INDIA TODAY's Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll.

Singh remains a favourite of composers like Pritam and Vishal-Shekhar who rely on his vocal talent. Such is its impact that his old tracks find resonance even today as evident in 2022's 'Kesariya' which continues to be an earworm. That Singh is sought-after is well-known, but it's the sheer volume of his hits in 2023 that demonstrate his supremacy. Last year, he was all over our airwaves, be it 'Jhoome Jo Pathaan' (*Pathaan*), 'Tere Pyaar Mein' (*Tu Jhoothi Main Makkaar*), 'Tum Kya Mile' and 'What Jhumka?' (*Rocky aur Rani kii Prem Kahaani*), 'Chaleya' (*Jawan*) or 'Lutt Putt Gaya' (*Dunki*). Sonu Nigam, who at 50 has made a return of sorts to playback singing, along with the now veteran Udit Narayan, rounded the top three.

Among the women, Shreya Ghoshal remains the reigning diva as she solidified her position by over three percentage points over the August MOTN. The 39-year-old artist is often the only female to feature in the annual year-end lists of most streamed artists. Ghoshal may not be as prolific as she was in the 2000s and early 2010s but she continues to be a beloved voice. 2023 saw her make her Coke Studio international debut collaborating with Egyptian rapper Afroto on 'Sunn Beliya', showcasing a singer who is open to pushing the boundaries, and also returning to the judge's chair in the latest season of *Indian Idol*. Far behind Ghoshal are Neha Kakkar and the evergreen Alka Yagnik. If there's one thing that binds Singh and Ghoshal together apart from their sheer talent, it's that both keep their social media engagements to a minimum, letting their songs do all the talking. ■

Q. Who is India's No. 1 singer (male)?

1. ARIJIT SINGH
38.3 [36.2]



2. Sonu Nigam
12.2 [11.6]



3. Udit Narayan
10.8 [10.1]



4. Jubin Nautiyal
5.4 [6]



4. Shankar Mahadevan
5.4 [5.6]

Q. Who is India's No. 1 singer (female)?

1. SHREYA GHOSHAL
39.6 [36.3]



2. Neha Kakkar
12.1 [12.7]

3. Alka Yagnik
10.7 [13.5]

4. Sunidhi Chauhan
7.2 [8]

5. Tulsi Kumar
5.9 [2.6]

All figures in %; rest, others; Feb. '24 figures in bold, Aug. '23 in [ ]